

SETTING THE TUNE RSS sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat with PM Modi at a function in Nagpur

a quiet but firm directive: no turncoats of recent vintage were to be appointed. The RSS wanted leaders who had risen organically within the broader parivar—those who understood ideological work and grassroots mobilisation, not just electoral strategy.

Exceptions were made in states where the party lacked a traditional base or wanted to experiment. Businessman-turned-politician Rajeev Chandrasekhar was made Kerala BJP president, while in Tamil Nadu, AIADMK defector Nainar Nagendran got the job (both have spent considerable time in the BJP). But, in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, seasoned Sangh loyalists P.V.N. Madhav and N. Ramchander Rao, respectively, were preferred.

There was also a discernible preference for MLAs/MLCs over MPs, who were seen as "too absorbed" in Delhi's power politics. Sangh sources say the aim is to cultivate a generation of ideological anchors for the next phase. It's all part of a long-term plan: a BJP national president who can guide the party into a post-Modi era, where charisma and centralisation may no longer suffice. The new state presidents are expected to complement this transition—restoring the BJP's image as a cadre-driven movement rather than a personality cult.

THE SANGH IS ENSURING IT HAS A SAY, SO THIS ISN'T JUST A DELAY, IT IS HAPPENING BY DESIGN. PARTY LEADERS PREFER TO CALL IT A 'STRATEGIC RECALIBRATION'

AUXILIARY APPOINTMENTS

On July 14, the evolving power dynamic was on full display. The Centre appointed three new governors, each a strategic signal. Prof. Ashim Kumar Ghosh, a relatively low-profile academic with deep RSS ties, was named governor of Haryana. In Ladakh, former J&K deputy chief minister and RSS loyalist Kavinder Gupta was appointed lieutenant governor—a move aimed at ideological consolidation in a sensitive region. In Goa, Ashok Gajapathi Raju, a former Telugu Desam Party (TDP) stalwart who is now with the BJP, got gubernatorial charge. Though formally in the BJP, Raju retains close ties with TDP chief Chandrababu Naidu and his appointment is seen as a subtle gesture of coalition management in NDA 3.0.

Just a day earlier, the party nominated four new Rajya Sabha MPs: historian Meenakshi Jain, RSS veteran C. Sadanandan Master, 26/11 special public prosecutor Ujjwal Nikam and ex-foreign secretary Harsh Vardhan